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FRESH MOMENTUM

THE INDIAN WOMEN'S HOCKEY TEAM HAS HAD A GOOD YEAR SO FAR AS IT PREPARES FOR THE UPCOMING NATIONS CUP IN JUNE AND THE WORLD CUP IN AUGUST

Since arriving in January, Sjoerd Marijne has had one focus—to put his house in order. To recreate the environment that helped the Indian women's hockey team finish fourth at the 2020 Tokyo Olympics and helped them break into the top-10 during his first stint as head coach. And Marijne had to work efficiently to lift the morale of a disjointed team ahead of an important year.

In March, India finished runners-up in the World Cup Qualifiers to make the cut. The following month, they bounced back from two losses to level the four-match series against World No. 2 Argentina. With confidence restored, Marijne started focusing on the targets ahead.

"I wanted the team to develop good habits and maintain discipline each day. Because good culture and good structure lead to winning matches. There's no other way," he says.

Skipper Salima Tete is aware of the philosophy, having played under Marijne in the past. Over the past two months, the team has worked on raising their fitness levels as well as individual skills, while trying to gel together as a unit.

"We played hard against Argentina and the result has given us confidence that we will carry into the next few tournaments. The coach has taken us through everything from the basics to working on the high ball. He has given juniors the opportunity to progress to the senior side and they have fit in quite well," Tete says.

Alongside junior women's coach, Tim White, Marijne has put in place similar systems for both teams that has ensured a smooth transition for teenagers such as Ishika and Sakshi Rana. He's



HARD STRIKE
The team celebrating their second goal against Wales at the FIH Hockey World Cup 2026 Qualifiers in Hyderabad, Mar. 11

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